Republic of the Philippines
CAMARINES SUR POLYTECHNIC COLLEGES
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COLLEGE of COMPUTER STUDIES

CS 3215 - Human Computer Interaction
LEARNING TASK (USER SUPPORT)

GROUP NO: 9 SECTION: A

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CRITIQUE OF THE EXISTING SYSTEM

USER SUPPORT TYPE 1: Online Documentation / Digital Brochure

[Screenshot: Pandayan Bookshop homepage showing the Digital Brochure tab and product listings without a shopping cart or checkout functionality]

How and When This Support Is Used:

The Pandayan Bookshop website primarily functions as an online documentation or digital brochure rather than a fully functional e-commerce platform. Users access this support when they want to browse available school and office supplies, check product categories, or view the digital brochure section. The site presents product listings but clicking "Buy Online" redirects users to external platforms like Lazada or Shopee, or instructs them to inquire at the nearest Main Branch. This form of user support is used during the discovery and browsing phase of the shopping journey, when users are looking up products before deciding to purchase. It provides read-only reference information — product names, photos, and brief descriptions — but fails to complete the shopping experience within the website itself.

USER SUPPORT TYPE 2: Quick Reference (Search Function)

[Screenshot: Pandayan Bookshop search bar returning inaccurate or close-by results for specific school supply queries]

How and When This Support Is Used:

The search function serves as a quick reference tool, intended to help users rapidly locate specific products without browsing through all categories. It is used when users — particularly students and teachers — need to find specific items such as ballpens, notebooks, or art materials. However, the current implementation is ineffective: the search algorithm returns inexact results when a product does not exist in the database, showing unrelated or loosely related items. This poor quick-reference experience causes confusion and frustration, often causing users to abandon the website entirely and visit a physical Pandayan branch instead.

USER SUPPORT TYPE 3: Store Locator (Task-Specific Help)

[Screenshot: Pandayan Store Locator showing only the Main Branch rather than the nearest branch based on user location]

How and When This Support Is Used:

The Store Locator feature serves as a task-specific help tool, designed to assist users in finding the nearest physical Pandayan branch when they cannot complete a purchase online. It is used during the decision-making phase — when users realize they cannot buy directly on the website and must visit a store. However, the current store locator always defaults to showing the nearest Main Branch rather than the closest community branch to the user's actual location. This makes the feature inaccurate and unhelpful, particularly for users in provinces or areas where a nearby smaller Pandayan branch may exist but goes unshown.

SCENARIO MAPPING: Three User Assistance Scenarios

Scenario	Description	Effectiveness of Existing Support
Scenario 1: Student searches for specific school supplies	A student needs to buy a specific brand of ballpen (e.g., Pilot G-2) for school. She uses the search bar on Pandayan's website to look for it. The search returns unrelated or loosely related results because the algorithm cannot handle brand-specific queries accurately, leading to confusion and eventual cart abandonment.	Ineffective. The search (quick reference) is inaccurate, violating the accuracy and completeness requirement of good user support. The user receives unhelpful results and has no fallback guidance within the website.
Scenario 2: Kaibigan Card member tries to use loyalty points online	A loyal Pandayan customer (Lowi) wants to use his Kaibigan Card points to get a discount when buying 100 notebooks in bulk. He cannot log into his Kaibigan Card account on the website, and there is no visible dashboard or help page explaining how to check or redeem points online.	Non-existent. The Kaibigan Card is mentioned on the website but has no online integration. This absence harms the user experience severely, as members feel their loyalty has no value online, violating the availability and consistency requirements of user support.
Scenario 3: User tries to find the nearest Pandayan branch for pickup	A teacher wants to order art supplies online but prefers to pick them up at a nearby Pandayan branch the same day to avoid shipping delays. He uses the Store Locator feature, which only shows the nearest Main Branch — not the community branches near his location, rendering the locator misleading.	Partially effective but inaccurate. The store locator exists as a task-specific help feature, but it fails the accuracy requirement by only showing Main Branches. It also lacks map view integration, making it obtrusive and unhelpful for the user's actual task.

PROPOSED REDESIGN STRATEGY

INTEGRATION PLAN	JUSTIFICATION
• Context-Sensitive Tooltips & Smart Search Suggestions: Implement an intelligent search bar with real-time autocomplete that suggests product names and categories as the user types (e.g., typing "ballpen" shows brands like Pilot, Faber-Castell). Tooltips will appear on product cards to clarify stock availability, branch availability, and payment options without navigating away from the current page. • Kaibigan Card Dashboard with Integrated Loyalty Help: Add a dedicated "My Account" section where Kaibigan Card members can log in, view their current points balance, and see an "Apply Points" button during checkout. An inline help wizard will guide first-time users through how to link their card and redeem points, functioning as a step-by-step tutorial support type.	• Context-sensitive tooltips and smart search directly address the accuracy and availability failures identified in Scenario 1 and the general browsing experience. For the target users — students and teachers who are often time-pressured — instant product suggestions reduce friction and support quick-reference needs without disrupting the shopping flow. This mirrors how leading platforms like Shopee and National Bookstore Online effectively implement search assistance. • The Kaibigan Card Dashboard resolves the critical disconnection in Scenario 2, where loyal members receive no online support. Appearing immediately upon login at the account page and at the checkout step, it targets the exact moment users need support regarding discounts and points — fulfilling the task-specific help and tutorial requirements of good user support design. It transforms a missing feature into a loyalty-reinforcing tool.

EVALUATING TRADE-OFFS

INTEGRATED SUPPORT METHODS	RISK MITIGATION
• Context-Sensitive Tooltips & Smart Search: Risk — Tooltip overload may clutter the interface, especially on mobile. Excessive autocomplete pop-ups may frustrate experienced users who already know what they want. The search suggestions could also slow down page performance if poorly implemented. • Kaibigan Card Dashboard & Loyalty Wizard: Risk — An intrusive login prompt or mandatory tutorial wizard could annoy returning users who have already set up their account. If the wizard is too lengthy or complex, users may skip it entirely, defeating its	• To mitigate tooltip clutter, tooltips will be hover-triggered only and collapsible — they will not appear automatically or block content. Smart search suggestions will be limited to five results maximum and designed with a clean, lightweight dropdown that disappears when not needed. Performance will be optimized by debouncing the search input so queries fire only after the user pauses typing, maintaining a smooth, unobtrusive experience consistent with the unobtrusiveness principle. • The Kaibigan Card tutorial wizard will be opt-in and skippable, appearing only

purpose. Poorly timed prompts (e.g., appearing in the middle of browsing) could interrupt the natural shopping flow.	on first login or when the user explicitly clicks a 'How do I use my points?' help link. Returning users will see only their points dashboard without any tutorial interruption. The login prompt will be unobtrusive — available as a persistent but small "Sign In" button in the navigation bar rather than a forced modal — ensuring the support remains available but never intrusive, as prescribed by good user support principles.

REFERENCES

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TAKEAWAYS

Name of Member: COLICO, Carl Renz M.
Contribution to the Group: Group Leader, Critique of the Existing System, Proposed Redesign Strategy, References
Learnings: Through this learning task, I realized how deeply the principles of user support — availability, accuracy, consistency, robustness, flexibility, and unobtrusiveness — apply to real-world systems that most people use daily. Evaluating the Pandayan Bookshop website revealed that poor or absent user support is not merely a technical inconvenience but a fundamental breakdown in communication between the system and its users. Identifying the three user support types that Pandayan already has — and critiquing where they fail — helped me appreciate how critical it is for any e-commerce platform to provide help that is present when needed but never intrusive. This task deepened my understanding that redesigning user support means thinking from the user's perspective at every touchpoint of their journey.

Name of Member: AQUINO, Sean Xander B.
Contribution to the Group: Scenario Mapping, Evaluating Trade-offs, Document Compilation

Learnings: This learning task showed me that user support is not just about having a "Help" page — it is about embedding assistance meaningfully at every point where a user might struggle. Mapping the three scenarios for Pandayan's website helped me see how the absence of proper support creates real frustration: a student who cannot find a product, a loyal member who cannot access their benefits, and a teacher who cannot find the nearest store. Evaluating the trade-offs was equally eye-opening — I learned that poorly implemented support can be worse than no support, because it clutters the interface and breaks user trust. The balance between availability and unobtrusiveness is delicate and requires careful, user-centered design thinking.

Name of Member: MONTENEGRO, John Renzzo C.
Contribution to the Group: Integration Plan Justification, Risk Mitigation Analysis
Learnings: Working on the proposed redesign strategy made me understand that choosing the right type of user support for the right moment in the user journey is as important as the quality of the support itself. Justifying why context-sensitive tooltips and a Kaibigan Card dashboard are the most beneficial support methods — compared to, say, a generic FAQ page — required me to think carefully about who our users are and what they actually need at each stage of shopping. Analyzing the risks of each integration also taught me that even well-intentioned help features can harm the user experience if they interrupt, confuse, or overwhelm. Good user support, as our lecture materials emphasize, must always be consistent, flexible, and unobtrusive.